

Increased biosecurity measures are in place for importing uncooked prawns and prawn products for human consumption in order to facilitate the safe trade of prawns while meeting Australia's appropriate level of protection (ALOP). These measures will remain in place while the department [undertakes a review](#) of the biosecurity risks and import conditions for prawns and prawn products for human consumption. If during this time the biosecurity risks change, the department may amend our import conditions to ensure they meet Australia's ALOP.

Enhanced import conditions for uncooked prawns and prawn products for human consumption are summarised below and also available in the [prawn products requirements table](#). Detailed information on import permit conditions can also be found:

- In the Biosecurity Advice Notice [2017-12 – End of prawn suspension and import conditions for prawns and prawn products for human consumption](#);
- Through Australia's Biosecurity Import Conditions database ([BICON](#)).

The department has implemented interim changes to import conditions to manage the biosecurity risks associated with *Enterocytozoon hepatopenaei* (EHP). Further detail is published in [Animal Biosecurity Advice 2020-A03](#).

For the most recent information regarding the management of recent detections of White Spot Disease in Queensland please see <https://www.outbreak.gov.au/current-responses-to-outbreaks/white-spot-disease>

Uncooked prawns, marinated prawns, non par-cooked breaded, battered or crumbed prawns and Australian uncooked prawns processed overseas (excluding those processed in an Australian government approved supply chain) are now consolidated into the one product class, uncooked peeled prawns.

Since July 2017, enhanced import conditions apply to imports of uncooked prawns, which are summarised in [Import Industry Advice Notice 65-2017](#). Import statistics including those consignments that have tested positive for WSSV on arrival in Australia, are available on the [Uncooked prawn consignments](#) web page.

The trading partners which have confirmed that they can meet Australia's import conditions for uncooked prawns can be found on the [List of approved countries and overseas authorities for prawns](#).

Consignments of imported uncooked prawns must meet biosecurity labelling requirements. These requirements include that:

- The primary packaging (i.e. the retail ready packaging) of the product is clearly labelled 'For human consumption only – not to be used as bait or feed for aquatic animals'.
- Primary packaging must include the batch number. Batch numbers can be the best before date, but must match the batch number identified on the health certificate.
- The labels must be freezer grade labels
- The labels must be permanent (i.e. not easily removable)

- The labels must be stable at -20°C.
- Secondary packaging (i.e. the outer carton) is not considered the primary or retail ready package

Importers should also be mindful of food labelling requirements with other regulatory provisions, including food standards developed by Food Standards Australia New Zealand (FSANZ).

Sampling of prawns

Samples of uncooked prawns for white spot syndrome virus (WSSV) and yellow head virus genotype 1 (YHV1) testing will be taken by Biosecurity Officers under secure seals intact conditions at Approved Arrangement locations.

Sixty-five prawns from 13 randomly selected cartons (5 prawns from each carton) will be taken from each importer-declared batch. A batch cannot be greater than one shipping container. Five prawns are pooled as one sample for testing.

The WSSV and YHV1 testing regime (the number of prawns taken from each batch of prawns) is designed to provide a 95% level of confidence of detecting WSSV or YHV1, if present, at a prevalence of 5% or greater in a batch of imported uncooked prawns.

Laboratory testing

Importers can nominate one of the three approved screening laboratories to conduct WSSV and YHV1 testing:

Agrigen Pty Ltd

Approved Arrangements Number: N2813

Address: Unit 1 of 6, Chaplin Drive, Lane Cove West, NSW 2066

Telephone: +61 2 8856 0988

Facsimile: +61 2 8856 0988

Email: info@agrigen.com.au

Elizabeth MacArthur Agricultural Institute

Approved Arrangements Number: N2338

Address: Virology Laboratory, Elizabeth MacArthur Agricultural Institute, Woodbridge Rd, Menangle NSW 2568

Telephone: +61 2 4640 6337

Facsimile: +61 2 4640 6429

Email: virology.enquiries@dpi.nsw.gov.au

Symbio Laboratories Pty Ltd

Approved Arrangements Number: N3003 & N3004

Address: 2 Sirius Road, Lane Cove West, NSW 2066

Telephone: +61 1300 703 166

Facsimile: +61 7 3219 0333

Email: admin@symbiolabs.com.au

The department has approved a standardised testing procedure for WSSV for testing imported prawns on-arrival. The standardised testing procedure has been adopted by all testing laboratories from 5 October 2017. The main requirements to implement the WSSV testing procedure are:

- The WSSV real-time PCR must run for 45 cycles.
- A negative result for the batch is where there is no amplification of WSSV DNA within 45 cycles in all 13 samples.
- A positive result for the batch is where there is detectable amplification of WSSV DNA before 45 cycles in one or more of the 13 samples.

When a screening laboratory reports positive results in a batch, the importer has the option to request confirmatory re-testing of samples at the Australian Centre for Disease Preparedness (ACDP), formally known as the Australian Animal Health Laboratory. The request for confirmatory re-testing must be communicated to the department within 5 working days of receiving the positive test result. All costs are borne by importers. No laboratories other than ACDP may carry out confirmatory testing.

Imported uncooked prawns that are deemed non-compliant will be directed for [cooking, disposing or exporting](#) as detailed below.

Applications to import uncooked prawns must include the name and address of the importer, manufacturer and exporter, and a description of the product to be imported. Any additional ingredients should also be provided in the application. It is recommended that applicants complete the uncooked prawns for human consumption questionnaire available through [BICON](#), as the same information is required to accompany the application.

The application will be assessed on the above information as well as any other criteria deemed relevant by the Delegate of the Director of Biosecurity.

Trade cannot commence if the country of export's Competent Authority hasn't confirmed that they can meet Australia's import conditions. Refer above to 'Countries that can meet Australia's import conditions' listed above for more information.

The department monitors the importation of uncooked prawns closely, and provides updated statistics on uncooked prawn consignments that have been imported into Australia since 7 July 2017.

Please see the following webpage: [Uncooked prawn consignments](#).

2. Imported breaded, battered and crumbed (BBC) prawns for human consumption

Since September 2018, BBC prawns must have undergone a par-cooking step after the prawns have been coated to solidify and adhere the coating to the prawn. For more information on par-cooking please see the following webpage: [Guideline – Acceptable par-cooking of BBC Prawns](#).

BBC prawns that have not undergone an acceptable par-cooking step must comply with the [import conditions for uncooked prawns](#) outlined above.

The trading partners which have confirmed that they can meet Australia's import conditions for breaded, battered and crumbed (BBC) prawns can be found at the [List of approved countries and overseas authorities for prawns](#).

Uncooked BBC prawns are subject to a 100 per cent secure seals intact fully supervised inspection regime on arrival. Containers must remain unopened and seals intact. Biosecurity Officers must remove the seals and verify the details of the consignment and the product as part of the inspection process.

Inspection procedures may also involve attempts to wash off the coating of thawed product and visual comparisons of the product at the border to the photos and information supplied at the permit assessment step to ensure consistency.

The department will assess all BBC prawn products when an importer applies for an import permit and apply the appropriate import conditions. It is recommended that applicants complete the uncooked prawns for human consumption questionnaire available through [BICON](#), as the same information is required to accompany the application.

Applications to import uncooked breaded, battered or crumbed prawn products must include the name and address of the importer, manufacturer and exporter, and certain information about the commodity to be imported. Further detail is available on the following webpage: [Guideline – Par-cooked BBC Prawns](#)

3. Imported cooked prawns and prawn products for human consumption

The department closely monitors imports of cooked prawns and prawn products to ensure import conditions continue to manage biosecurity risks appropriately. If biosecurity risks are considered to have changed, the department will amend import conditions accordingly.

From 4 June 2018, the department introduced random seals intact fully supervised inspections for cooked prawn consignments. These randomly selected inspections provide additional assurance that import conditions for cooked prawns are being met. Import conditions require that:

- As a result of the cooking process all protein in the prawn meat has coagulated and no raw prawn meat remains; and
- All consignments are accompanied by a health certificate issued by the competent authority that confirms the above.

Samples of the product will be taken during the inspection and the department will advise on the outcome within five working days.

Prawns or prawn products that are imported and deemed non-compliant will be directed for [cooking, disposal or exporting](#) as detailed below.

4. Other relevant information

Brokers and importers are encouraged to contact the department to book inspections for consignments that have been directed for inspection. This will assist in reducing delays and assist the department with planning inspection activities. To request an appointment, complete the [request for inspection form](#) and email it to the department in the location where the cargo is held.

Biosecurity Industry Participants (BIPs) and importers need to be aware of the following prior to Biosecurity Officers attending premises to conduct inspection and sampling of goods:

- Inspections can only be conducted at the approved arrangement site that the department has approved for the inspection of imported prawn products. For more information, see [class 2.5 requirements for prawn and prawn products](#).
- Containers must remain unopened and seals intact. Biosecurity Officers must be present to inspect and verify the seal number, and then supervise the breaking of the seal and open the container as part of the inspection process. If the seals are not intact, the inspection will not proceed and product will be deemed non-compliant.
- Two Biosecurity Officers will attend each seals intact inspection.
- Fee for service rates will apply for each officer.
- Expected duration of inspection is a minimum of four hours, however, it may vary depending on the quantity to be inspected, the number of batches to be sampled, etc.
- Additional labour to assist Biosecurity Officers with handling cartons during the inspection should be considered. Please note: Biosecurity Officers will be present for the entire duration of the unpack and charges apply for the total time taken.
- The importer is responsible for all transport costs prior to and after inspection, including cargo handling, additional labour and cold storage fees.

Prawns that are imported and deemed non-compliant must be [cooked, disposed of or exported](#) as outlined below.

Cooked prawns also remain subject to the imported food inspection and testing regime. The department will undertake biosecurity and imported food inspections at the same time where resourcing permits. However, importers may be required to make a separate appointment for imported food inspection and testing. This may cause an additional delay in the release of the goods.

Failing to comply with a Biosecurity direction is a breach of the Biosecurity Act 2015. Interference with the goods prior to inspection by a biosecurity officer will result in a direction to export being issued and possible civil or criminal prosecution. Enforcement action may be instigated where non-compliance is identified.

Batches of imported uncooked prawns, BBC prawns or cooked prawns that fail to meet import conditions must within a reasonable time period (usually 28 days) be:

- Exported; or
- Disposed of at a facility with an approved arrangement; or

- Treated (i.e. cooked) at a facility with an approved arrangement.

The ACDP is available for confirmatory re-testing of uncooked prawn samples that have failed virus testing. The request for a confirmatory re-test must be communicated within 5 working days to the department upon receipt of the positive test result.

Disposal or treatment of prawns

The following fact sheets are available for disposal and cooking procedures of prawns:

Export of prawns

Biosecurity Industry Participants (BIPs) and importers need to be aware of the following requirements when they elect to have the goods exported:

- Departmental officers will supervise the export of all uncooked prawns and BBC prawn products where the importer has elected to export the goods.
- For goods that have not been unpacked and remain in the container in which they were imported, an officer will verify that the details of the consignment (e.g. container number) and the seal number match the import documentation and the seal is intact prior to the goods being exported.
- For goods that are being packed for export, a departmental officer will need to be in attendance for the duration that the container is being packed. The officer will verify the details of the goods being packed into the container and that a seal has been applied to the container prior to the goods being exported.
- Two officers may be required when the goods are packed into a container.
- Fee for service rates will apply for each officer.
- Expected duration for a seal check will be a minimum of thirty minutes.
- Expected duration for the packing of a container is expected to be 2 hours, however, it may be longer. Please note: officers will be present for the entire duration of the pack and charges apply for the total time taken to complete the packing and seal the container.
- An adequate safe inspection area is required during the cargo packing operations.
- The importer is responsible for all transport costs prior to and after inspection, including cargo handling, additional labour and cold storage fees.
- To request an appointment, complete the [Request for inspection form](#) and email it to the department in the location where the cargo is held.
- The [Request for permission to dispose of goods/conveyance form](#) must be completed.

Movement procedures for failed consignments of prawns

The department has developed a [factsheet](#) outlining requirements on the movement of prawn consignments that failed to meet import conditions. Movement procedures outlined in the factsheet apply for any non-compliant consignment of prawns or prawn products.

If you wish to report suspicious activities related to imported prawns that may be of a biosecurity concern, please call the Redline number on 1800 803 006. For more information, please see the department's [suggestions, compliments and complaints](#) webpage.

5. Reviews of biosecurity risks

The Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry has commenced a review of the biosecurity risks of, and import conditions for, prawns and prawn products into Australia.

- The department [announced the commencement of the review](#) on 16 May 2017 - ([Biosecurity Advice 2017/07](#)).
 - The review will consider all biosecurity risks associated with prawns and prawn products imported for human consumption, not just those associated with WSSV.
 - Further information about the review can be found on the department's website at [Review of prawns and prawn products from all countries for human consumption](#) or email [Prawn review](#).

On 17 February 2017, the then Inspector-General of Biosecurity, Dr Helen Scott-Orr, formally advised the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry of her review into biosecurity issues surrounding the outbreak of WSSV in Queensland.

The final report, which included the department's response to the recommendations, was published on 12 December 2017 and can be found at the Inspector General of Biosecurity's website by following the link:

On 21 March 2017, the Senate adopted the recommendations from the Senate Rural and Regional Affairs and Transport References Committee's report Import of seafood and seafood products, including prawns and uncooked prawn meat into Australia and referred the matter for further inquiry. The final report was published on 31 October 2017. The [Government's response](#) was tabled in Parliament on 25 May 2018. The final report, submissions, and the Government's response can be found at the [Parliament of Australia website](#) for the biosecurity risks associated with the importation of seafood and seafood products (including uncooked prawns and uncooked prawn meat) into Australia.

The government takes the issues raised in these reviews very seriously. The recommendations support the work already undertaken to ensure the integrity of Australian biosecurity.

The majority of the key issues have been identified and addressed by the department including:

- introducing enhanced import conditions and strict inspection and testing measures at the border.
- undertaking a comprehensive review of the biosecurity risks of, and import conditions for, prawns and prawn products for human consumption.

The remaining recommendations from these reviews are part of the department's ongoing review, and where necessary improvements, to biosecurity controls that manage the importation of prawns. Implementation of the response to some recommendations involves consultation and collaboration with state and territory governments and industry.

6. Publications

January to December 2020

January to December 2019

January to December 2018

January to December 2017

January to December 2018

Date	Description
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2 July 2018	Response to Four Corners, 2 July 2018
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2 July 2018	Four Corners White Spot testing conclusions flawed
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January to December 2017

Date	Description
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12 Dec 2017	Inspector-General of Biosecurity white spot review
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3 Nov 2017	Update on prawn consignments imported under enhanced import conditions
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2 Aug 2017	White spot syndrome virus testing at retail outlets
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30 Jun 2017	Enhanced import conditions for uncooked prawns to take effect from 7 July
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15 Jun 2017	Planned changes to import conditions for uncooked prawns
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1 Jun 2017	Update on white spot disease in prawns, 1 June 2017
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16 May 2017	Review of import conditions for prawns and prawn products
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20 Apr 2017	Department's action on imported prawns - update April 2017
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10 Feb 2017	Department's action on imported prawns
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13 Jan 2017	No definitive source of prawn disease has been found
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7 Jan 2017	Federal agriculture department suspends uncooked prawn imports
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December 2016

Date	Description
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23 Dec 2016	Update on white spot disease in Queensland
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16 Dec 2016	Update on white spot disease in Queensland
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9 Dec 2016	Update on white spot disease in Queensland
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2 Dec 2016	Detection of white spot disease in Queensland prawns
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May 2018

This document is to be completed by importers and submitted to a departmental biosecurity officer during the inspection process for uncooked prawns.

Download

Document	File size
Uncooked prawn sampling declaration PDF	98 KB
Uncooked prawn sampling declaration DOC	313 KB

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

7. Contact information

For importing goods into Australia, including how to apply for an import permit, certification requirements, import conditions and queries related to BICON, please contact Imports:

Email: [Imports](#)

Phone: 1800 900 090

For enquiries related to the status of a consignment, test results, clearance and inspection of goods, re-exporting, destruction or transportation of goods, please email or phone the department in the location where the cargo is held, or contact the Client Contact Group:

Phone: 1800 900 090

For queries on the current review of import conditions for prawns and prawn products for human consumption:

Email: [Prawn review](#)

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/goods/uncooked-prawns>